ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Wish, if only and regrets

Use unreal past and past perfect forms to express present dissatisfaction, past regret and desired change. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use wish, if only and regrets to separate a present unreal wish, a past regret and a complaint about changeable behaviour while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Use unreal past and past perfect forms to express present dissatisfaction, past regret and desired change.

MODEL

I wish I had asked more questions.

wish / if only + past simple | past perfect | would

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main wish, if only and regrets patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses separate a present unreal wish, a past regret and a complaint about changeable behaviour.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in personal reflection, tactful criticism and narrative commentary.

Build meaning before form

Use unreal past and past perfect forms to express present dissatisfaction, past regret and desired change.

What wish, if only and regrets communicates

Use unreal past and past perfect forms to express present dissatisfaction, past regret and desired change.

The central purpose is to separate a present unreal wish, a past regret and a complaint about changeable behaviour. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

I wish the office were closer.	dissatisfaction with a present situation
I wish I had asked more questions.	regret about a completed past choice
I wish the printer would stop making that noise.	a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: wish / if only + past simple | past perfect | would. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “I wish I had asked more questions.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Present wish	wish + past simple	I wish the office were closer.
Past regret	wish + past perfect	I wish I had asked more questions.
Desired change	wish + would + base verb	I wish the printer would stop making that noise.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
dissatisfaction with a present situation	Present wish
regret about a completed past choice	Past regret
a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change	Desired change

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in personal reflection, tactful criticism and narrative commentary. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04
wish / if only	past simple	past perfect	would

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: separate a present unreal wish, a past regret and a complaint about changeable behaviour.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits personal reflection, tactful criticism and narrative commentary.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Present wish	wish + past simple	I wish the office were closer.
Past regret	wish + past perfect	I wish I had asked more questions.
Desired change	wish + would + base verb	I wish the printer would stop making that noise.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

I wish the office were closer.	dissatisfaction with a present situation
I wish I had asked more questions.	regret about a completed past choice
I wish the printer would stop making that noise.	a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use a present tense after wish for an unreal present situation.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use would have for your own completed past regret.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Avoid wish would for fixed states that are not volitional or changeable.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: dissatisfaction with a present situation?

OPTIONS I wish the office were closer. · I wish I had asked more questions. · I wish the printer would stop making that noise.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: regret about a completed past choice?

OPTIONS I wish I had asked more questions. · I wish the printer would stop making that noise. · I wish the office were closer.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change?

OPTIONS I wish the printer would stop making that noise. · I wish the office were closer. · I wish I had asked more questions.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “I wish the office were closer.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS dissatisfaction with a present situation · regret about a completed past choice · a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “I wish I had asked more questions.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS regret about a completed past choice · a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change · dissatisfaction with a present situation

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “I wish the printer would stop making that noise.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change · dissatisfaction with a present situation · regret about a completed past choice

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"I wish the office were closer." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Present wish / Past regret / Desired change · Gap 2: dissatisfaction with a present situation / regret about a completed past choice / a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"I wish I had asked more questions." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Past regret / Desired change / Present wish · Gap 2: regret about a completed past choice / a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change / dissatisfaction with a present situation

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"I wish the printer would stop making that noise." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Desired change / Present wish / Past regret · Gap 2: a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change / dissatisfaction with a present situation / regret about a completed past choice

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses dissatisfaction with a present situation: _____. Choose the model that expresses regret about a completed past choice: _____. Choose the model that expresses a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change: _____. Choose the model built with wish + past simple: _____. Choose the model built with wish + past perfect: _____. Choose the model built with wish + would + base verb: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

I wish I had asked more questions. · I wish the office were closer. · I wish the printer would stop making that noise.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

I wish the office _____. I wish I _____ more questions. I wish the printer _____ making that noise. State the full structural pattern for Present wish: _____. State the full structural pattern for Past regret: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The office is not close enough.” using the Present wish pattern to express dissatisfaction with a present situation.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “I did not ask enough questions.” using the Past regret pattern to express regret about a completed past choice.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The printer keeps making an annoying noise.” using the Desired change pattern to express a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The office is not close enough.” using the Present wish pattern to express dissatisfaction with a present situation.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Present wish to express dissatisfaction with a present situation, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Past regret to express regret about a completed past choice, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Desired change to express a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

I wish the office were closer.

Present wish is the best match because dissatisfaction with a present situation.

A2

I wish I had asked more questions.

Past regret is the best match because regret about a completed past choice.

A3

I wish the printer would stop making that noise.

Desired change is the best match because a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change.

A4

dissatisfaction with a present situation

The Present wish pattern communicates dissatisfaction with a present situation.

A5

regret about a completed past choice

The Past regret pattern communicates regret about a completed past choice.

A6

a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change

The Desired change pattern communicates a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Present wish / dissatisfaction with a present situation

The structure belongs to the Present wish pattern. Its communicative purpose is dissatisfaction with a present situation.

B2

Past regret / regret about a completed past choice

The structure belongs to the Past regret pattern. Its communicative purpose is regret about a completed past choice.

B3

Desired change / a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change

The structure belongs to the Desired change pattern. Its communicative purpose is a complaint about behaviour or a situation expected to change.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

I wish the office were closer.

Present wish: wish + past simple.

C2

I wish I had asked more questions.

Past regret: wish + past perfect.

C3

I wish the printer would stop making that noise.

Desired change: wish + would + base verb.

C4

I wish the office were closer.

Present wish: wish + past simple.

C5

I wish I had asked more questions.

Past regret: wish + past perfect.

C6

I wish the printer would stop making that noise.

Desired change: wish + would + base verb.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

were closer

Present wish requires “were closer” in this model. wish + past simple.

D2

had asked

Past regret requires “had asked” in this model. wish + past perfect.

D3

would stop

Desired change requires “would stop” in this model. wish + would + base verb.

D4

wish + past simple

Present wish is built as wish + past simple.

D5

wish + past perfect

Past regret is built as wish + past perfect.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

I wish the office were closer.

wish + past simple. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended present wish effect.

E2

I wish I had asked more questions.

wish + past perfect. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended past regret effect.

E3

I wish the printer would stop making that noise.

wish + would + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended desired change effect.

E4

I wish the office were closer.

wish + past simple. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended present wish effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

I wish the office were closer. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses wish + past simple accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

I wish I had asked more questions. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses wish + past perfect accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

I wish the printer would stop making that noise. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses wish + would + base verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____